As of October 13, 2026

Chihiro WATANABE

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Education

Hitotsubashi University, Tokyo, Japan *Apr 2026 –*
Ph.D. in Economics

Hitotsubashi University, Tokyo, Japan *Apr 2024 – Mar 2026*
M.A. in Economics
Thesis: *"Testing a Macroeconomic Model of Mental Health: Evidence from Micro-Level Causal Inference"*

Hitotsubashi University, Tokyo, Japan *Apr 2020 – Mar 2024*
B.A. in Economics, Valedictorian (*Summa Cum Laude*)

Research Interests

- Health Economics (Mental Health)
- Information Economics (Rational Inattention)
- Computational Psychiatry

Research

Work in Progress

- **Rational Delusions** (joint with Hiroki Oi, M.D., Ph.D., psychiatrist and clinical researcher)
  - Initiated an interdisciplinary collaboration integrating economic theory with psychiatric and clinical insights.
  - Develop a rational-inattention model of delusional belief updating in which an agent optimally chooses how to process and interpret information about the world, taking information-processing costs into account. The model provides a unified account of the "paradox of delusions," characterized by the coexistence of two seemingly contradictory features: jumping to conclusions (JTC)—large shifts toward delusional beliefs based on weak evidence—and bias against disconfirmatory evidence (BADE)—insufficient belief revision even in response to strong counterevidence.

- **Social Epidemiology of Mental Health** (joint with Takashi Oshio)
  - Explore machine-learning approaches, including decision trees and clustering, to identify data-driven multidimensional deprivation profiles associated with mental health risk using Japanese panel data.

Master's Thesis

- **Testing a Macroeconomic Model of Mental Health: Evidence from Micro-Level Causal Inference**
  - Replicated in Julia a heterogeneous-agent life-cycle model in which mental health shapes economic decisions through rumination and pessimistically distorted beliefs.
  - Evaluated its quantitative implications using PSID panel data and staggered adoption of state mental health parity laws within a staggered difference-in-differences framework, bridging structural modeling with reduced-form causal inference.

Research Assistant Experience

- QuantEcon *May 2026 –*
  - Supervisors: Prof. Thomas J. Sargent and Prof. John Stachurski
  - Contribute to maintaining and modernizing open-source materials in computational economics, including NumPy/Numba revisions and textbook review.
- Institute of Economic Research (IER), Hitotsubashi University *Aug 2021 – Mar 2024*
  - Supervisors: Prof. Reiko Gotoh and Prof. Ryo Kambayashi
  - Cleaned and organized survey data for a capability-based study of older adults and persons with disabilities in Kunitachi City.

Fellowships, Honors & Awards

(HU stands for Hitotsubashi University.)

Selected Participant, RIKEN CBS Brain Science Training Program (BSTP) *2026*
Selected for the Regular Course of the RIKEN Center for Brain Science's training program.

Best Presentation Award, Four-University Joint Research Presentation Meeting, HU *2026*
Selected as the top presentation among 70 posters in the JST SPRING Program.

JST SPRING Fellowship ("The Bridge to the Future" in HU) *2026 – Present*

Moritani Ikueikai Scholarship *2025 – 2026*

Valedictorian, HU *2024*

Summa Cum Laude (President's Award), HU Economics *2024*

President's Award (for Outstanding Achievement in a Paper Competition), HU *2024*

Scholarship for Academic Excellence, HU *2023 – 2024*

President's Award (for Highest Academic Performance in Economics, 2022), HU *2023*

Teaching Experience

- Intermediate Macroeconomics (Master's level) *Fall 2024*
  - Instructor: Prof. Takashi Kano
  - Grading of assignments and exams / Office hours (student support)

Skills

Programming: Julia, Stata, Python, LaTeX
Languages: Japanese (native), English
Tools: Git, Overleaf, VS Code